

Huntington 1968 RG Notes

Huntington, Samuel P. *Political Order in Changing Societies*.

New Haven: Yale University Press, 1968.

1 Main Idea

When economies and societies modernize, the resulting increase in political consciousness can lead to unrest and instability as participation outpaces institutionalization. To maintain order, political institutions must modernize as well, developing sufficiently as to satisfy this increased participation. This goes against previous intuition (the liberal or “Whig” argument) suggesting that economic growth should organically result in political stability, and suggests that political institutionalization must be intentional and structured. Institutional development may fall into revolution when existing state capacity is low and calls for change are met without an institution to consider and implement them. Conversely, well-developed and strong institutional structures may be able to change via reform instead, whereby development follows from the existing institutional structures and occurs in a more controlled manner.

2 General Notes

- Social and economic development preclude political development: just having economic growth does not improve political outcomes unless institutions are also formed to shape them
- When social structures are strong or homogenous, they may take the form of political institutions – but, in their absence (or when there are many), we need political institutions to effectively coerce government
- Madison Federalist 51: “In framing a government which is to be administered by men over men, the great difficulty lies in this: you must first enable the government to control the governed; and in the next place oblige it to control itself.”
- Mature institutions have their own goals, incentives, traditions, etc. – they no longer simply serve those who created them, but they further serve themselves
- Argues that what is good for institutions is usually good for the country and is in some

way a representation of the “public good” – that institutional strength is commensurate with effective governance

– Subclaim: governments are “good” when their actions reflect the desires/goals of their institutions. *Alignment between institutions and their leaders/operators*

- Trust inhibits organization, which inhibits political stability
- Modernization involves an openness to new ideas and change, and an expansion of knowledge about one’s environment:
 1. “Political modernization involves the rationalization of authority, the replacement of a large number of traditional, religious, familial, and ethnic political authorities by a single secular, national political authority.” Man begins to rationalize and question authority, requiring power to be centralized with reason rather than by tradition
 2. “Political modernization involves the differentiation of new political functions and the development of specialized structures to perform those functions.” Complexity is tied to modernization; recognize the need for certain tasks
 3. “Political modernization involves increased participation in politics by social groups throughout society.” Political participation broadens
- Unrest is tied towards the speed of modernization: rapid development lends instability while gradual development can allow for a moderated and more peaceful transition
- Political unrest *requires* economic growth: in total abject poverty, unrest essentially cannot exist (think oxygen-starved)
- Three-step relationship:
 1. Social mobilization outpacing economic development → social frustration
 2. Social frustration outpacing mobility opportunities → political participation
 3. Political participation outpacing political institutionalization → political instability
- Corruption occurs in response to this last tradeoff: political participation outpaces opportunities for participation, and so participation becomes unstructured and disorganized
- Modernization breeds corruption in three ways: core point is that not only do behaviors change, but perceptions of those behaviors do as well. Moving target of what constitutes corruption
 1. Modernization involves a change in the basic values of society – new behaviors may have previously been seen as corrupt, or vice versa. Changing expectations for the role of public figures and institutions. Also ties back to earlier points about questioning legitimacy of authority. May be a result of blurred line between public and private interests

2. Modernization creates new sources of wealth and power whose relation to politics is not presently defined
 3. “Changes it produces on the output side of the political system” – generally leads to more laws, which themselves offer more opportunity for corruption at every stage
- Top-heavy corruption is commensurate with very low political development, but developed political systems often have bottom-heavy corruption (i.e., corruption is much more severe with local officials and institutions than national). US an example of the former; Trump era pushing towards the latter
 - Corruption can speed economic development: brings in groups that would otherwise be marginalized, push through bureaucratic oversight, etc. US in 1880s-1890s is key example (think large monopolies)
 - Defines a “Green Uprising” process. First, urbanites develop and unseat rural elites. Then, violence/tension forms between ruling urbanites and remaining rural population en masse. Green Uprising refers to the alliance of some sector of the rural population with some sector of the urban population – i.e., a workers’ movement – that subsequently overcomes these impasses and brings stability. However, forms of this uprising may differ, particularly in (a) who is part of the movement and (b) what the goals/targets of the movement may be
 - “A society is vulnerable to revolution only when the opposition of the middle class to the political system coincides with the opposition of the peasants. Once the middle class becomes conservative, rural rebellion is still possible, but revolution is not.”
 - Three levels of political participation:
 1. Low: only the elites participate
 2. Medium: the aristocracy has some participation as well as portions of the upper-middle classes, but the “masses” remain generally excluded
 3. High: The entire population takes part in the political process

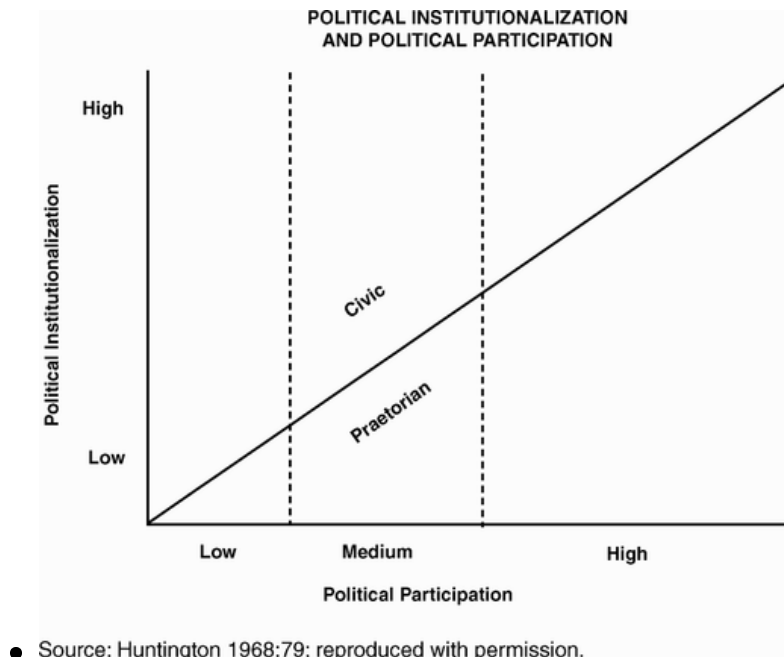


Figure 1

- “As political participation increases, the complexity, autonomy, adaptability, and coherence of the society’s political institutions must also increase if political stability is to be maintained.”
- Praetorian: low institutionalization, high participation. Lack of formal means of decision-making or adjudication – “social forces confront each other nakedly.” Civic: high institutionalization, low participation; stable and recognizable patterns of institutional authority. High cost of authority limits resources that may be employed in politics and how groups may influence institutional processes
- Military intervention in politics is a reflection of underdeveloped institutions: the current system cannot appropriately satisfy the demand for participation; this is equivalent to how church, tribes, and other social groups become hyperinvolved in politics
- Revolution is much more rapid than reform and follows when there is not sufficient institutionalization to handle modernization – instead, the increase in political participation spins out of control and requires almost a total overhaul of existing institutions. Conversely, reform occurs when the appropriate institutional capital is in place to manage these shifting needs, desires, and definitions of the selectorate; it is slower and more peaceful, but generally results in changes in institutions rather than total reconstruction
- Reform needs to be balanced: it must be fast enough to work and “keep the dogs at bay”, but slow enough to remain under control. This requires strong, rather than weak, governments

3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- Communist governments are highly effective at governing and establishing legitimate authority: “Men may, of course, have order without liberty, but they cannot have liberty without order. Authority has to exist before it can be limited, and it is authority that is in scarce supply...”
- “Modernization in practice always involves change and usually the disintegration of a traditional political system, but it does not necessarily involve significant movement toward a modern political system.” At this time, developing world had significant broad modernization, but not modernization of political systems – just degradation, which led towards totalitarianism
- By drawing further consciousness to existing groups/social ties, modernization usually increases short-term conflicts and often results in fundamentalist religious movements. Creates group prejudice, which in turn creates group conflict
- Education and literacy are specifically tied to political stability... “It is not the absence of modernity but the efforts to achieve it which produce political disorder.”
 - Counterpoint: “In numerous underdeveloped countries the standard of living in the major cities is three or four times that prevalent in the countryside, yet the cities are often the centers of instability and violence while the rural areas remain quiet and stable. Political extremism is also typically stronger in the wealthier than in the poorer areas.”
- quoting from Conroe: “The higher the rate of change toward modernity, the greater the political instability, measured statically or dynamically.”
- “At one extreme, some measure of economic growth is necessary to make instability possible. The simple poverty thesis falls down because people who are really poor are too poor for politics and too poor for protest.”
- “Social mobilization is much more destabilizing than economic development.”
- Agrarian systems hinder mobility: limited opportunities for advancement within the agricultural sector
- “The parties which at first are the leeches on the bureaucracy in the end become the bark protecting it from more destructive locusts of clique and family.”
- Modernization often increases gaps (including political) between urban and rural areas – rural areas remain politically underdeveloped, but also with lesser need for enhanced political development (hence, why they generally remain peaceful). Also tends to create social disunity between these two cohorts that must be resolved to avert violence and unrest

- “The sources of instability in a modernizing society are seldom in its poorest or most backward areas; they are almost always in the most advanced sectors of the economy”
- “The extent to which the instability of the city manifests itself depends upon the effectiveness and the legitimacy of the political institutions of the society. Urban instability is minor but universal. Rural instability is major but avoidable.”
- “Almost all praetorian oligarchies eventually evolve into radical praetorian systems.”

4 My Critiques

- Huntington is highly focused on institutional order rather than individual liberalism. This isn’t necessarily a bad thing, but: while he warns of overly-burdensome institutions, he may underplay the potential costs of this institutionalization. Namely, he seems to suggest a rather monotonic relationship between state capacity and state quality that neither (A) satisfies contemporary normative claims nor (B) explain sustained instability in authoritarian regimes. Empirically, the work is heavily focused on the “stability” of Communism and the Soviet Union, which we now know to be untrue.
- Very specific procedural claims: X, then Y, then Z. Often there are at least some cases which support his transitions, but there are just as many which do not. For example, discussion of rapid urbanization, then overthrow of the rural elites by the urbanites, then partnership of urbanites and rural residents, is not an implausible pathway, but may be overly generalized here
- Not sure if his support of complexity is sufficiently nuanced. Do complex institutions really provide unilateral gains, or can decreased complexity better support high participation? Furthermore – if high participation brings lower-educated cohorts into the political sphere, would highly complex systems become increasingly problematic? Could be a populism/demagoguery issue as well – that which is not understood by the masses can be interpreted as animous